

The firm

Costa & Vale is a 14-person accountancy in Porto. Two partners (Inês Costa, tax; Rui Vale, accounts), eight accountants, two juniors, one office manager (Teresa), one part-time IT contractor.

Clients: ~180 SMEs and self-employed people. Work is seasonal: VAT every month, CIT and personal tax in the spring peak.

They already pay for Sage (books) and a shared Google Drive. Several staff use personal ChatGPT to rewrite emails. Inês is uneasy about client data in consumer tools. A software vendor offered them an “AI accountant agent that files and emails clients on its own.” Rui is tempted because they cannot hire another senior before April.

You are a BA student on a two-week project. The partners asked for a bounded pilot, not a transformation plan.

The messy reality (read twice)

Workflow under pressure: client questions in inbox and WhatsApp

Teresa and the assigned accountant answer the same things all day: “When is VAT due?”, “Can I deduct the new laptop?”, “What documents do you still need?”, “Why is my draft bill so high?”

- Volume: ~70 questions per week in peak, ~25 off-peak.
- About 40% are repeats of last year or of the firm’s own emails.
- About 30% need a look at that client’s folder.
- About 20% are judgment (grey deductions, “is this allowed?”).
- About 10% are complaints or fee disputes.

Today the path is: message arrives → Teresa forwards → accountant searches Drive / Sage / memory → types a reply → sometimes Inês reviews if the client is large. Average first reply: **11 hours**. Repeat questions: **one in four** clients ask again because the first answer was vague.

Other pains the partners mentioned (do **not** solve all of them in this canvas): - Juniors spend Fridays assembling document-request lists.

- VAT return preparation is slow in March.
- Rui wants dashboards.
- The vendor demo filed a dummy VAT return in one click.

What exists (you may use this)

Source	What is in it	Quality
"Client FAQ 2023.docx"	19 Q&As Inês wrote	Out of date (rates changed)
Drive / Clients / [name]	Contracts, prior returns, emails	Folders inconsistent; some only on Rui's laptop
Sage	Books, deadlines, billed hours	Good for numbers; not for advice wording
WhatsApp Business	Half of incoming questions	Not copied into the client folder
Personal ChatGPT chats	Draft replies	No log; two clients' names already pasted

There is **no** official "current tax position" file. There is **no** rule for when a junior may send without a partner.

Constraints the partners already set

1. No system may file a return or send a bill.
2. Client data must not go into a personal consumer account.
3. A partner still signs anything that is tax advice, not a deadline reminder.
4. Budget for a first test: **€150/month** and **two Fridays**.
5. They will not replace Teresa.

Your job

Fill **all canvas fields** for **one** decision/workflow. Recommended scope:

Drafting replies to repeat client questions, using only official firm text, with a human sending the message.

You may argue for a smaller slice (e.g. deadline reminders only) if you can defend it in boxes 03, 05, and the four gates.

You may **not** choose “AI files the VAT return” unless you also write a kill criterion and a commit boundary that would survive a regulator. That choice will be marked harshly if you skip control fields.

How to use the canvas (map)

Canvas box	What to pull from the case
01 Objective	Pick one outcome: speed, quality, risk, or cost. Not all four.
02 Problem	Cost of the current inbox path. Use the numbers.
03 Process	Who decides what, how often, what happens after.
04 Stakeholders	Partners, Teresa, accountants, juniors, clients, contractor.
05 AI role	Draft / retrieve / classify — say what it must not do.
06 Human–AI	Who hits Send. Who reviews tax-advice vs reminder.
07 Data	Which of the five sources are allowed; what must be cleaned first.
08 Tools	Least clever stack that fits the €150 cap.
09 Redesign	New path from WhatsApp/email → draft → send → file the answer.
10 Evaluation	Baseline 11 hours / 25% repeats. Add safety checks.
11 Economics	Time back vs leak risk vs vendor fantasy.
12 Implement	Owner, two Fridays, who logs overrides.
Four gates	Smallest test; one assumption; one kill line; what Inês decides after.

Header: project name, team name, member names, date.

Quality bar (how you will be marked)

- **Specific process**, not “digitise the firm.”
- **Commit boundary** is named (a person, not “the AI”).
- **Data** is official or you said you will write it first.

- **Kill criterion** is observable in weeks.
- You resisted the vendor agent unless the control boxes are stronger than the demo.

Automatic low mark: unsupervised client email, filing a return, or “roll out Copilot to everyone.”

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Optional twist (if a pair finishes early)

Add five lines at the bottom of the Markdown export:

1. What you refused to automate and why.
2. The sentence you would put on Teresa’s wall.
3. One number you would collect in week 1 before any tool goes live.